REP-010 · Theme review: does Fruit Market's theme support how it plays?

Game	Fruit Market
Report date	2026-10-26 21:47 (Asia/Kuala_Lumpur)
Request	Apply the "Game Concept and Theme Companion" (edition 1.0) to this game
Build reviewed	`main @ 83de99b` (release 1.1.1 candidate); content in `src/engine/data.ts` and `RULES.md`
Type	Creative review only. **No game, rule or content changes were made.**
Approval status	DEC-014 proposed; DEC-015 and DEC-016 **awaiting your choice**

The direction is already chosen and the game is live, so this follows the companion's path for an existing game: check what works, review coherence, propose the smallest useful test. No new concepts.

1 · Creative brief (what is confirmed, what is assumed)

Item	Status	Value
Player fantasy	Confirmed (game brief)	Run a fruit stall; outsell rival shops before your stock goes bad
Core interaction	Confirmed (rules)	Buy from the farmers, set secret prices, reveal, age overnight
Players and session	Confirmed	2–4 shops; Quick 8 / Standard 10 / Long 14 days; 10–20 min (assumption, unmeasured)
Platform	Confirmed	Phone browser and Android; touch first
Audience	**Assumption**	Casual players 12+, families sharing a phone, friends online
Desired feeling	**Assumption**	Light, cheeky tension: "will my price win?" plus "sell it before it rots"
Setting and identity	**Open**	See section 4

2 · Does the theme show up in what players do?

Repeated action	How the theme expresses it	Fit
Buying at the farmers market; poorest buys first	A morning market where small shops get first pick	**Strong**. The catch-up rule feels like market goodwill
Fruit ages each night; older fruit sells for less; spoiled fruit is binned	The freshness track and "Not so" fruit	**Strong**. This *is* the fantasy; every choice is a race against rot
Secret prices, all revealed at once; cheapest sells first	"Showdown" reveal, customer by customer	**Mixed**. Exciting and fair, but real stalls post prices openly. The reveal needs a stall-side reason (presentation idea in section 5)

Repeated action	How the theme expresses it	Fit
Customers with orders and price caps	24 named characters with quirks	**Strong** for orders and caps. The quirks are cosmetic (they never change play), which is fine but should stay labelled cosmetic
Events (Heatwave, Health Inspector, Lorry Breakdown…)	Each bends the market in a believable way	**Strong**. Heatwave aging fruit and the Inspector fining old fruit are the best theme-mechanic matches
Upgrades (Handcart, Cool Room, Juice Press, Signboard…)	Things a stall owner would actually buy	**Strong**
Favour cards	Rewards for serving a whole order yourself	**Mixed**. "Free Cash" and "Good Riddance" read as abstract game cards rather than market favours
Rival shops (animal traders)	Six characters with reaction lines	**Mixed**. Fun, but personality and play style don't match: lines are cosmetic, and how cleverly they price comes from difficulty, not character

Overall the core loop expresses the fantasy well. The weak spots are presentation: why prices are secret, a few abstract card names, and cast identity. None needs a rule change.

3 · Proposed design pillars (for your approval: DEC-015)

Pillar	Include when…	Exclude when…
1. Fresh fruit, fast money: every decision is a race against spoilage	It makes freshness visible or raises the cost of waiting	It lets fruit sit forever at no cost, or hides freshness
2. Outprice rivals in secret: commit a price blind, then see the reveal	It keeps prices hidden until the reveal and makes the reveal explain *why*	It shows rivals' prices early, or adds open haggling or chat
3. A cheerful town market: playful characters, short sessions, readable on a phone	Jokes target behaviour (a vampire who hates garlic); games stay under about 20 min	Mean or stereotype-based jokes, grind, pay-to-win, long text

4 · Coherence issues found (review before expanding)

1. **Mixed setting identity** *(owner decision, see question 1)*:
    - Customer names are Malaysian and multicultural (Aisyah, Mei Ling, Kumar, Wei Jie), and one rival is "Uncle Toad".
    - The palette is Mediterranean (terracotta, harbour teal, olive).
    - Prices are in **$**, and the fruits are blueberry, watermelon, apple and mango (two are imports in Malaysia).

    It reads as "anywhere town". That's fine, but it isn't a choice anyone made deliberately.

2. **Possible ethnic association:** "Panda Lim" pairs a Chinese surname with a panda. Most other names pair freely with professions or fantasy roles (Astronaut Aisyah, Ninja Farid), so this one stands out. Recommend renaming it (cosmetic only). "Kumar the Genie" is milder; worth a second look.

3. **Why are prices secret?** The best moment in the game has no in-world reason. That's a presentation fix, not a rule change (section 5).

4. **Repeated jokes:** each rival has 2–3 lines per situation, and a 10-day game has many reveals, so lines probably repeat. Hypothesis; check in the playtest.

5. **Icon style:** some emoji still sit beside the pixel art (🔒 Prices locked, 📊, 🙋/🤖, 🕵). Already in backlog B-33.

5 · Representative day (actual rules)

Day 4 of 10, Standard game. You and Foxy Rosa (computer). You have $14; she has $19.

1. **Morning:** the event is 🔥 **Heatwave**: watermelons sell for $4 more, but all fruit ages an extra step tonight. Tomorrow's event, shown early: 🕵 Health Inspector.
2. **Buy:** you're poorer, so you **buy first**. Fresh watermelon costs $3. You take 3 and leave the cheap blueberries: in a heatwave they'd rot by tomorrow. *Choice: profit now vs. stock that survives tonight.*
3. **Customers:** Cowboy John wants 2 watermelons and pays up to $6 + 4 = * *10** for fresh ones.
4. **Secret price:** you offer 2 at **$9**; Rosa secretly offers 2 at $8.
5. **Showdown:** prices flip; the cheapest sells first. Rosa's $8 fills John's order, and you sell nothing. Rosa quips "A dollar cheaper. Sorry, not sorry!" *Feedback:* your offer is tagged "$1 too high".
6. **Evening:** you build the ❄ **Cool Room** ($7). Your fruit now ages only every other night, and heatwaves can't touch it. *Choice: spend on protection or keep cash for tomorrow.*
7. **Night:** heatwave aging hits Rosa's shelf. Your Cool Room saves your 3 watermelons for tomorrow's customers, and tomorrow's Inspector will fine Rosa for her old fruit.

Theme-only idea for pillar 2 (not approved, no rule change): present secret pricing as *chalkboards*. Each stall chalks its price face-down, the market bell rings, and the boards flip. Same rule, with a market reason.

6 · Mini creative bible (draft: samples only, per the companion)

- **World and tone:** a sunny town market where anyone might shop: cowboys, astronauts, a vampire after sunset. Light, cheeky, never mean. Stakes: a good day's takings, never ruin.
- **Sample character:** *Grandpa Tan* (cosmetic). Silhouette: cardigan, cane, paper bag. Desire: a fair price. Flaw: remembers when apples cost ten cents. Sample reaction when you sell at full price: "Ten dollars? In my day..."
- **Sample event:** *Health Inspector*. The clipboard arrives at night; every Not-so fruit costs $2. This teaches "sell old fruit first" without a tutorial line.
- **Key screen:** the reveal. Face-down boards flip highest to lowest, the winner's coins fly to their stall, and the losing offer is tagged "$1 too high". It works without sound and without colour alone: text plus movement.
- **Do:** jokes about what characters *do*; short lines; a mix of names and roles across cultures. **Avoid:** pairing a person's ethnicity with an animal or cultural cliché; jokes longer than one line; new lore that doesn't change a decision.

7 · Riskiest creative hypothesis and the smallest test (DEC-016)

Hypothesis: first-time players understand *why* they won or lost a sale at the reveal. That is pillar 2, and it's what makes the game feel fair rather than random.

Format: a playtest with the existing game (preview or live 1.1.1). **No code needed.** It can't tell us retention, market demand or online-server behaviour.

Playtest card

Testers	3–5 people who have never played; no coaching
Setup	Their own phone. New game → Quick (8 days) → 1 computer shop (Normal)
Tasks	1) Start a game. 2) Buy fruit. 3) Set your prices. 4) After the first sales, say why you sold or didn't. 5) Finish the game
Watch for	Time to first price; whether they mention "cheapest sells first" or freshness; whether they read the event card; where they hesitate
Ask after	"What were you trying to do?" "Why did you lose that customer?" "Would you play again?" (note if they start another game unprompted)
Provisional criteria (you set them; these are suggestions, not benchmarks)	**Continue** if at least 3 of 4 can explain a lost sale by day 3. **Revise** (reveal presentation, section 5) if 2 or fewer can
Limits	Small sample; friends are kind; not proof of fun or retention

I'll record what happens (observations separate from interpretations) in the next report.

8 · Questions for you (max 3)

1. **Where is this market?**
   - (A) "Anywhere town": keep as is. *Recommended for now:* costs nothing and doesn't affect the biggest risk.
   - (B) A Malaysian pasar: RM prices, local touches; the fruit artwork could change later; much bigger art scope.
   - (C) A deliberate mix ("a market where the whole world shops"): keep the names, lean into variety.
2. **Rename Panda Lim** (and review Kumar the Genie)? Recommended: yes, a cosmetic change in a later small package.
3. **Can you find 3–5 people who've never played** for the playtest card above?

9 · Decisions

ID	Question	Recommendation	Status
DEC-014	Use the Concept and Theme Companion for Fruit Market's creative work, alongside the development workflow	Yes; one shared record system	Proposed
DEC-015	Adopt the three design pillars (section 3)?	Yes	Awaiting approval

ID	Question	Recommendation	Status
DEC-016	First creative test = the reveal-comprehension playtest (section 7)	Yes; no code	Awaiting approval

No conflict with approved decisions: release 1.1.1 (DEC-013) is unaffected, and nothing here changes rules, saves or multiplayer.